

## Hexa-core soon

Intel's new six-core processor, the Core i7 980X looks all set to break records

## GW990 smartphone

LG shows off the GW990 smartphone which is powered by the Atom processor and runs Moblin



Photography: Jiten Gandhi

**Choosing the right netbook isn't as easy as it seems. We feature the hottest netbooks you can buy in this two-part test. You can read part two online at [www.thinkdigit.com/d/netbook\\_test](http://www.thinkdigit.com/d/netbook_test)**

hardware. Therefore a netbook is a tradeoff of sorts, fortunately it's good at what it's supposed to do. Brands like Intel, AMD and NVIDIA are working on making netbook hardware more powerful and this should happen over the next year or so, but the notion of playing a game like *Crysis* on a netbook is so ridiculous, don't even think of it for at least another three years!

We've split up our netbook test into two cohesive writeups – the first part consisting of seven netbooks, is what follows here on.

# Small Surfers

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**T**hey were always cheap, but netbooks have become mundane enough to be compared to cellphones. Why? – Nearly everybody has one, and those that need one have no dearth of choice. Of course the hardware found in netbooks isn't as diverse as in their faster, bulkier cousins, notebooks, and some might feel that keypad and screen size aside, there are very few differences. Well, this was true until a few months back. AMD entered the netbook space early last year; followed by VIA (now that's a name we haven't heard in some time!) with their Nano

CPU. NVIDIA has a solution that hasn't seen many takers in the Ion – a combination of Intel's Atom processor and NVIDIA's own 9400M northbridge. NVIDIA is also threatening to enter the netbook space with their Tegra range and in lieu of all the above, netbooks have gotten much needed variety in terms of hardware. Intel's own Pinetrail debuted recently. For those not in the loop, Pinetrail is nothing more than a new version of the Atom CPU, integrating a memory controller, DMI link and GMA 3150 graphics core.

Initially netbooks typically featured 10-inch displays and this underlies both, one of the major plus points and pitfalls that plague them. The small

screen means a small footprint and lower weight. This, in turn, is the darling of many a traveller who wishes to be connected at all times. A netbook is lighter than nearly all notebooks and much cheaper; very convenient for most cadres of people including businessmen, college goers, travelling executives and almost anyone wanting the internet with a bit of documents and spreadsheets thrown in. However the small screen is a turnoff for many. After all, everything is moving to a visual interface and everyone likes a large screen. Multimedia is also a big no on a netbook, the weak hardware being the culprit here. So games, HD movies and multitasking is simply too much of a strain for such paltry

## MSI U130

### Of sails and wind

Short of height and of wide girth, is how we'd like to describe the U130. Its footprint is small, thanks to the 10-inch display, however, it could have been smaller. Although any smaller and the keypad would have become unnecessarily cramped, as it is it's barely usable. The U130 is squat though, unnecessarily so, thanks to the absence of any sort of streamlining of the body on MSI's part and an extruding battery pack. It feels pretty solid and the plastics used are pretty thick and without flex, unlike some flimsier stuff we've seen in the past. A glossy black lid embossed with fine dark grey lines is nothing